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Inside a peaker power plant

Facilities are key to connecting Will County solar farms to the grid

By John Lippert and Alicia Fabbre
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As Earthrise Energy looks to fire up solar farms across Illinois, the key to making them useful is directly linked to the five natural gas power plants it's spent the last few years purchasing.

The facilities in Will County and near Champaign are so-called peaker plants that Illinois, in an effort to limit air pollution, now allows the company to run only during times of maximum demand for electricity.

For the next half century, Earthrise plans to use the peaker plants' existing connections to the state's power grid to ship electricity from the solar farms it's building nearby, bypassing a lengthy approval process to connect to the grid. This strategy surprised many Will County residents who only learned of the full scope during the past eight months. Earthrise, though, remains unapologetic.

"Prices are going up right now for electricity in Illinois, and if we don't build solar, what choice have we got?" Ron Kalbous, the company's development director, asked during a tour of the Manhattan plant last week. "We can't build new gas plants. We can't build new coal plants."

"Every time people flip the light switch on, or look at a TikTok video, or flip on Netflix, or post something to Facebook, they're making a vote for solar, because solar is the only way to feed that demand."

However, the scale of the Manhattan Township project alone — sprawling across 45 square miles of prime Illinois farmland — raises its own challenges. State-mandated limits on local zoning authority restrict the county's ability to regulate the project, leaving Will County Board members with tough choices as they prepare to vote Thursday on special zoning permits.

At the meeting, the board will consider the 600-megawatt Manhattan solar farm proposal and a similar 260-megawatt facility in nearby Crete.

They'll also reconsider six smaller projects they'd already rejected. They're doing so after the solar operators involved sued, and

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Pope Leo 'not afraid' of Trump's rhetoric

Message of Gospel cited in peace appeal; president's posts decried

By Will Weissert, Josh Boak and Nicole Winfield
ASSOCIATED PRESS

ABOARD THE PAPAL PLANE — U.S.-born Pope Leo XIV pushed back Monday on President Donald Trump's broadside against him over the U.S.-Israel war in Iran, telling reporters that the Vatican's appeals for peace and reconciliation are rooted in the Gospel, and that he doesn't fear the Trump administration.

"To put my message on the same plane as what the president has attempted to do here, I think is not understanding what the message of the Gospel is," Leo said aboard the papal plane en route to Algeria. "And I'm sorry to hear that, but I will continue on what I believe is the mission of the church in the world today."

Before his departure from Rome, the pontiff told reporters: "I'm not afraid of the Trump administration or of speaking

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"We are not politicians. We do not look at foreign policy from the same perspective that he may have. Too many people are suffering today, too many innocent people have been killed, and I believe someone must stand up and say that there is a better way."

— POPE LEO XIV

Above: Pope Leo XIV speaks to journalists aboard a flight bound for Algiers' Houari Boumediene International Airport on Monday, at the start of an 11-day apostolic journey to Africa.

ALBERTO PIZZOLI/GETTY-AFP

Area Catholic leaders express support for Chicago native pontiff

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Several local Catholic leaders expressed support for Chicago native Pope Leo XIV on Monday after President Donald Trump called the Holy Father "weak" and "terrible" in a rambling social media post amid a rapidly escalating feud between the Vatican and White House over the U.S.-Israel war in Iran.

Peoria Bishop Louis Tylka said Trump's message was "very disappointing," adding that it was "below the dignity of the office for the president to launch a personal attack on our Holy Father Pope Leo."

"Pope Leo is not a politician. He is a pastor. He is the vicar of Christ," Tylka said during a Monday phone interview with the Tribune. "And he's speaking the Gospel truth which calls us all to show respect for one another and find ways to solve conflicts which don't include war."

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Bill Rosales, left, and Jason Fuggiti at the outpatient center at Loyola University Medical Center in Maywood on April 7. Fuggiti donated a kidney to Rosales, who was battling a rare genetic kidney disorder.

TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Firefighter facing 'death sentence' gets kidney from fellow firefighter

High school friend volunteers to make a life-saving sacrifice

By Rebecca Johnson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Bill Rosales had struggled for months to ask for help by the time he got a call from a high school friend. The Chicago firefighter desperately needed a kidney transplant to treat a rare genetic disorder.

He hadn't spoken much in several years to the friend, Jason Fuggiti, who also happens to be a firefighter in the southwest suburbs. Rosales assumed he was

simply checking in on his health, so he was floored by Fuggiti's announcement.

"He goes, 'Well, I just left Loyola hospital... and I got a kidney for you whenever you need it,'" Rosales, 47, of Dunning, said.

"I was so shocked," he continued. "I had no idea he even knew I needed a kidney. I had no idea he'd already started the process to get tested and got cleared. I was saved by my old high school buddy."

Although Rosales initially kept his diagnosis quiet, when his fellow firefighters learned about his search for a donor, they posted on social media and hung up posters in firehouses across the city. Rosales, who received the success-

ful transplant last month after years of declining health, was "overwhelmed" by the support.

In fact, Megan Parker, Loyola Medicine's transplant coordinator, said there was such a "large influx" at one point that it was impossible to get through all the applications. Ultimately, at least 30 people expressed interest in donating, much more than the three people that's typically considered high, Parker said. Another friend even decided to donate his kidney to a stranger when he wasn't a match.

For Fuggiti, it was an easy decision to go through with the donation, in large part because of the

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First piping plover sightings

Pippin and Imani were spotted Monday at Montrose Beach. Imani is the son of beloved pair Monty and Rose. Pippin was last seen last summer with a piece of hair caught around his foot. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

US starts blockade of Iran ports

President Donald Trump said that the American military had begun a blockade of Iranian ports as part of his effort to force Tehran to open the Strait of Hormuz and accept a deal to end the war. **Nation & World**

Sky take UCLA guard in draft

The Chicago Sky selected guard Gabriela Jaquez with the No. 5 pick in the WNBA draft, taking a swing on one of the lower-rated of the six draft prospects from UCLA's national championship team. **Chicago Sports**

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